

Gout Medication Side Effects: What to Ask Your GP

Practical NHS-backed advice on gout medication side effects what to ask your gp.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: Common gout medications include allopurinol (urate-lowering), colchicine (acute flare treatment), and NSAIDs. Each has specific side effects: allopurinol can cause a rash; colchicine causes diarrhoea at higher doses; NSAIDs affect the stomach and kidneys. Always report side effects to your GP rather than stopping medication independently.

Most people with gout will need medication for either acute flare treatment or long-term uric acid management. Understanding potential side effects helps you manage them effectively.

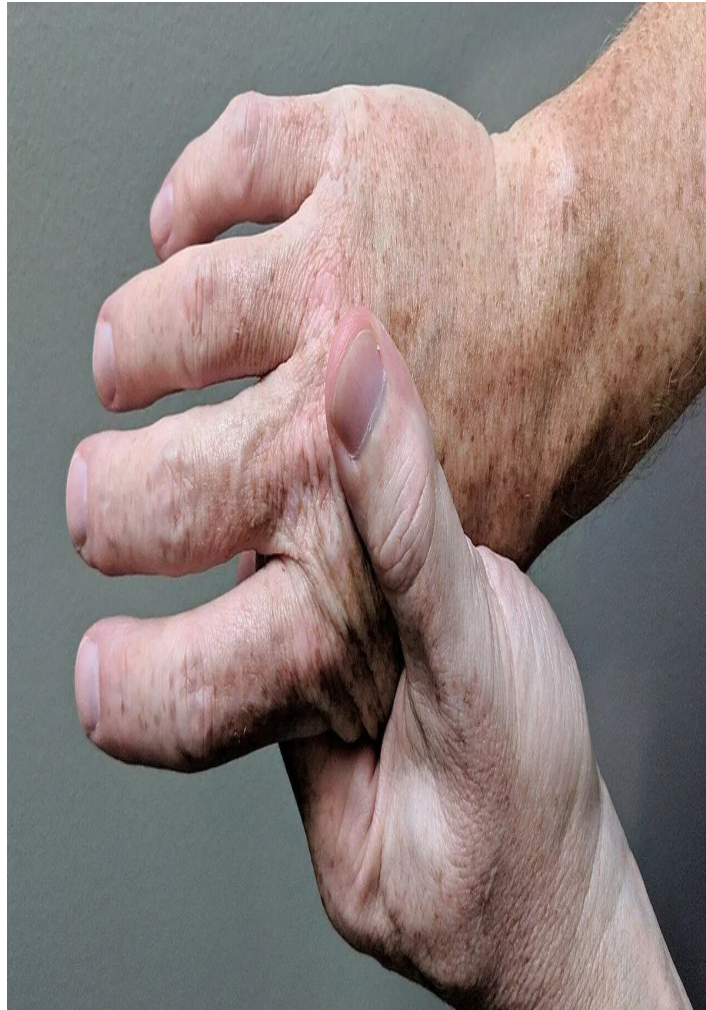
Allopurinol (Urate-Lowering Therapy)

Allopurinol is the most commonly prescribed urate-lowering therapy, taken daily long-term to prevent attacks. It is generally well-tolerated but has important side effects to know about.

Questions to Ask Your GP About Allopurinol

- "What does the allopurinol rash look like and when should I stop immediately?"
 - "How often will you check my kidney function and uric acid levels?"
 - "Will it cause more gout attacks at first?" (it can — this is normal and temporary)
 - "Can I take it with my other medications?" (interaction with azathioprine is serious)
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Colchicine and NSAIDs



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Colchicine is effective for acute gout but causes dose-dependent diarrhoea, nausea, and stomach cramps. NSAIDs (ibuprofen, naproxen) carry risks with long-term use: stomach ulcers, raised blood pressure, and reduced kidney function. Use at the lowest effective dose for the shortest time.

Q&A;

Question: Should I stop allopurinol during a gout flare? **Short answer:** No — NICE guidance recommends continuing allopurinol during a flare. Stopping and restarting can prolong the attack.

Question: How do I recognise the dangerous allopurinol rash? **Short answer:** If you develop a widespread, blistering, or peeling rash, stop immediately and go to A&E; — this may indicate

Stevens-Johnson syndrome, a rare but serious reaction.

Question: Can I take ibuprofen and colchicine together for a gout flare? **Short answer:** Possible but discuss with your GP first. NICE recommends monotherapy (one drug) for most acute gout attacks.

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